[redacted]

27/8/25

TO: Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters

This submission cross references past and present experience as
i) employee of both Federal and State Electoral Commissions (1993–2007)
ii) constituent; participant in seeking law reform via ONE submission to a NSW Act Review (2012), incurring a 13 year trailing impact....
iii) spouse of candidate for 2023 NSW State election (for a major Party)

to highlight the need for law reform on matters relating to electoral laws and practices and their administration.
With the three levels of government (Federal, State, Local) intertwined, and with greater political party influence at local level, the need for uniformity in some procedural matters is raised.
Honesty and integrity, with a respect for the basic human right to speak and be heard without interference (psychological or physical) is mandatory.
I note that the existence of ANY "Standing Committee on Electoral Matters" was UNKNOWN to the author (or spouse) prior to the 2023 NSW State Election. A prior issue remains relevant for reasons noted. State issues also reverberated into the Federal arena.

A: Electoral Law

1. Recognition of "psychological harm" in the Electoral Act, in accordance with its impact on
   i) constituents
   ii) candidates (and spouse)
   iii) employees of Electoral Commission(s)
   iv) the PARTY system (all levels of government)

via the deliberate perpetration of misinformation (and intimidation) to cause debabilitation (psychological) of the victim(s) to effect

electoral outcome.

- In conjunction with the health system, to provide pathway(s) for victim(s), to incorporate compulsory attendence at a mediation session whether the abuser chooses to verbally participate or NOT, so as to provide closure for the victim(s) (NOT psychological deterioration / suicide).

- Recognition current law permits legal mind altering drug prescription without the requirement for patient clinical assessment, doctor knowledge of 'pre-existing' psychological conditions, or relationship counselling etc.

  Appendix A1 provides further detail regarding inclusion of this matter.

2. Electoral Roll Review

- Needs to be aligned with Medicare records re - name, address, DOB for greater "accuracy."

- Requires reassessment of permissible reasons for voter NON-INCLUSION on the roll in lieu of increased 'Pre-Poll' voting days.

- Reassess use/misuse of voter details for non-electoral purposes. The electoral roll information is SOLELY for electoral purposes!

- Provide either a pathway for legal removal from the electoral roll (in distressing cases like mine)
  OR seek recognition of the impact of deliberate psychological harm perpetrated "from the electoral process"
  OR provide constituents with the right to be placed on the electoral roll in a different electorate (and Party).

3. Electoral Boundaries

Consideration be given to State borders (as defined by rivers eg. Murray) NOT being the determinent for Federal Election boundaries, especially considering

- Albury/Wodonga Mealth crosses the Murray River.
- Current country electorate boundarys (eg. Farrer) require a aeroplane to successfully traverse the terrain to represent the people!

I suggest border towns ie Albury/Wodonga; Moama/Echuca; Coolangatta/Tweed Heads be better represented by boundarys "crossing states" to fill constituent number requirements.

B: Electoral Practices

1. Staff training

The "manual" should include reference to "voter privacy", as applicabl to
- the electoral roll (ie non-disclosure of voter details as they appear,
- voting procedure (at booths).

For polling officers returning for "counting" after election day, a "standard" few pages in a leaflet would NOT go astray, for reference to the requirement for procedures to maintain "privacy" rights when "opening absentee envelopes", for instance. Reference material would be held by Electoral Commission divisional headquarters.

2. Employment by Electoral Commission of a independent "scrutineer" to randomly oversee procedures are being adhered to.
I note, Party scrutineers rarely stay at a COUNT unless a close result is expected. Also, polling officer employment is generally short term, high stress, with a 3-4 year gap, so "refreshment" of procedures is essential at ALL staff levels (esp. NEW staff).

3. Resource sharing where practicable, between Federal and State Electoral Commissions be established to minimize costs.

4. Candidate issues

Signage

- Review permissability of the use of 'Coreflute' in regard to biodegradability (Appendix A2)

- Candidate responsibility for removal of public (and private) signage where publically visible (ie. inside farm fences on public roads) within a set time period following a election, to acknowledge "cessation" of the election.

- Ban on the use of trees (especially in roadside reserves) for the display of signage especially as it inhibits fauna (koalas, possums etc) scampering quickly from predators.

5. Enforcement of 'Electoral Practice Law'

.... That it be implemented!

6. Analysis of the 2025 Federal Election should include consideration of:

a. Number (or %) of informal votes
b. Number (or %) of eligible voters NOT on electoral roll (c/w Medica
c. Number of eligible voters ON electoral roll who did NOT vote
d. Cost of "fine" recovery (for not voting) vs income received for fines.
e. Administration cost of the election

to determine % of voters OVERALL not interested in the electoral process, to determine WHY!

The future ... Non compulsory voting?
Public education re- the political process?
Recognition of psychological abuse?

7. Public/employee/candidate awareness of the role of Electoral Commissions; Standing Committees on Electoral Matters to be increased to have issues raised from "witnesses" to events, and dealt with by respective bodies.

APPENDIX

A1 : Impact of psychological harm

From electoral process to constituent seeking law reform

Forwarding ONE submission to a NSW Act Review (2012) which raised both State and Federal reform issues (without realisation at the time) has left a 13 year trailing impact on personal health, from

a. Misuse of electoral roll information (at State level) to deliberately forward printed material (via a "birthday card") from the State MP's office, with distressing salutation (considering my personal traumas) then his office refusing a meeting with him to discuss the issue.

Reporting the matter to :

i) NSW Electoral Commission apparently resulted in a investigation with minor reform, but the primary issue was not addressed ie 'Why' should I receive the card, when never before, did either my husband or I receive such material from ANY MP? And, during the election campaign, this MP met with me, at our home, where I raised the issue of concern and suggested reform proposal. Only years later, did a friend indicate evidence of the reform.

NOTE

Electoral Commission practice of

a) NOT letting the 'complainent' KNOW if a investigation will occur OR NOT, or the outcome IS distressing !!

ii) PARTY officials resulted in the suspected spread of misinformation to my Federal MP (same Party), incurring my placement on a perpetual "waiting list", denying me further representation (at both levels).

NOTE

Personal meetings and correspondence with that Federal MP for the previous (10 ?) years on the 'core' issue had NEVER been an issue.

A request to be removed from the electoral roll was denied, with only an offer of "Silent Voter" status. I declined. My husband and I made a personal decision to leave our

home (of 32 years) due to non-representation by elected members, and continuing 'stress events' (unprecedented) at the local level. Federally, meeting requests with the MP (since election) receive non-acknowledgement.

ii) Candidates and spouse

I refer here, to experiences in the 2023 NSW State Electon, with its impacts still relevant Federally, as psychological harm events are NOT recognised in law.

Public defamation (verbal) of candidates (or spouses) is not proveable unless recorded. I experienced

- verbal defamation (of my husbands Party) directed at ME, for NO apparent reason(s). Note I remain non affiliated with ANY political party, and was unaware of the legal requirement (if any) to only help ones spouse if politically aligned to that Party. He experienced a deficit in "help", so I acted humanely!!

- association of clothing colour with PARTY alignment, with verbal comment to that effect!

- suspected 'influence' from the sitting candidate (seeking re-electio on personal involvement in local events (NOT associated with the election) causing stress.

All events 'combined' to severely affect health at the time.

NOTE

I AM NOT sure of electoral law BUT ANY questions re - a candidates breach (possible) of the Electoral Act, should remain between the candidate, "complainent" and the Commission without media involvement, with "innocent until proven guilty" in place, so as NOT to affect candidate psychological health (and physical) or impact on electoral results by the delay taken to complete a investigation (by the Commission).

iii) Employee of the Electoral Commission(s)

Employment began with the Federal Electoral Commission (1993) entailing fairly comprehensive training re-procedures (and explanation for their existence), in [redacted], as polling place officer (election day) AND vote counting (following 2-3 weeks). Training involved face to face interaction with senior staff, provision of the reference manual, and a brief explanation before each count procedure of what was to be done, and why, often by the Divisional "head." The message imparted always was "NEVER be afraid to ASK if unsure!"

2007 State Election Count

Employees were informed to open absentee(?) envelopes face up, without a letter opener, with voter name (and address?) visible, then to place voting papers face up, revealing voter intention. I informed a co-worker (long time employee friend) that this "was not right." He kept quiet. I then informed the supervisor, who informed the NEW "divisional head". No scrutineer was present. Next day I brought my own letter opener. The 'divisional head' then arrived, SLAMMING a dozen openers down on the table in front of me. Subsequently, all materials for group use were "slammed" in front of me! I finished my term of employment but CEASED Electoral Commission employment. Years later I learnt (from my friend) the "head" had a baby .... and was probably experiencing hormonal changes!

NOTE

Both Electoral Commissions LOST a trained staff member (without my reporting of events to them).
Worker harrassment needs ATTENTION, with the provision of suitable pathways for resolution of issues without incurring penalties to address the psychological issue!
Documented in NSW State Records is a report, suggestedly correlating the 'intimidation' side effects of a legal mind altering drug (prescribed without patient assessment on 'victims', without patient realisation.

iv) 'Coercive' impact through the Party system, State to Federal (or vice versa) designed to impact on electoral result.

- Note earlier reference (A1 ii)

- With reference to March 2025 Federal Election. I note the "Coincidence" of the role of my previous State MP (National/Liberal coalition) in his engagement re-a 'fact finding mission" for the Nuclear Energy policy proposal by the Federal coalition.
I acknowledge Liberal Party (1975) decision to abandon the policy idea. The question remains 'who' re-booted the idea considering the volatility of the issue re-humanity impacts (re-disposal of nuclear waste!) If anyone wanted to influence (negatively) a polling result, what better topic to adopt.
COINCIDENCE that the relationship between State and Federal governments has NEVER been harmonious (behind closed doors).
COINCIDENCE this conflict (continues) personally has ignited personal awareness from a number of issues confronting me.
COINCIDENCE that the State MP himself, was not personally impacted by the electoral result.
COINCIDENCE the 'split' temporarily occurred post election results with Federal Nationals gaining the 'upper hand' re-agreement made.
In effect, a "revolution" without public awareness.
Agreements COULD have been entered into privately without choice of "such a topic", which if successful, would have severely impacted NOT just Australia, but the WORLD!!

<u>NOTE</u>

"Coercive" impact MAS to be experienced to be understood as with the detrimental long term impact of intimidation.

A2: Coreflute (from Company information – internet)
"Coreflute is NOT biodegradable ...." theoretically ... (coreflute) will eventually degrade through photo-oxidation, in practice this will take hundreds of years."

Reuse merely delays inclusion in landfill.